

CLIPPED WINGS

They are not driven by idealism or ideology but money and muscle power. The youth fronts of political parties are no longer the laboratories of new leadership.

■ By Priya Sahgal

*Bliss was it in that dawn to be alive,
But to be young was very heaven.*

—William Wordsworth

It was India of the 1970s, when a 26-year-old Sitaram Yechury won his college presidential election debating the merits of Stalin versus Trotsky; when a 23-year-old Arun Jaitley went to jail for organising one of the first few protests against the Emergency; and a cavalcade of opposition leaders led by A.B. Vajpayee and L.K. Advani drove up to the Rashtrapati Bhavan to protest against the rustication of 20-something Vijay Goel, the then Delhi University (DU) president, for leading a march against the vice-chancellor. It was the age of the Naxalbari movement, the Nav Nirman and the Emergency. The pulse of political agitation was located on the college campus. For the young and idealistic, it was the right time to be young and idealistic. Today when student activists are jailed, it is for murderous assaults on their professors and not for any ideological cause. The romance of the revolution is lost and aggression is the new rhetoric.

"The youth, by definition, are anti-establishment. Look at America and England, they are capitalist countries. So student leaders at Oxford and

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